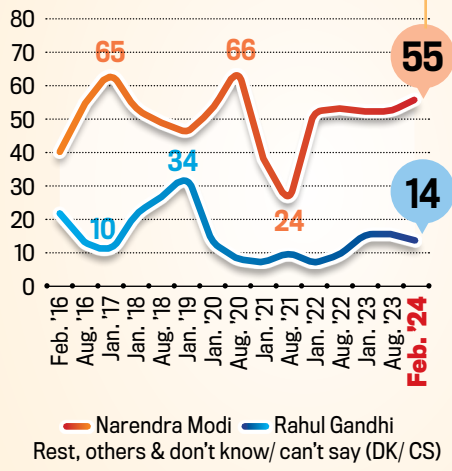
Q. Who is best suited to be India's next prime minister, Narendra Modi or Rahul Gandhi?



The confidence reposed in Modi has grown. Only one in seven respondents favour Rahul

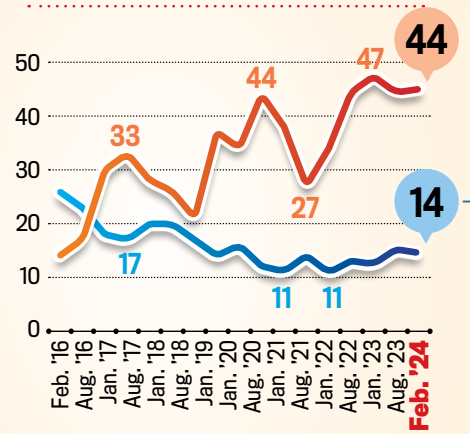






Narendra Modi vs Indira Gandhi

How the MOTN surveys have reflected the popularity trends of two of India's prime ministers known for radical moves



Currently, Modi's popularity far outstrips that of Congress stalwart Indira, the tallest leader of her era

All figures in % and rounded off

January 2014 exercise, when the Congress-led United Progressive Alliance (UPA) was seeking a third succesive term in government. The MOTN survey just months before the 2014 election predicted that the UPA's tally would crash to 100 seats—a steep fall of 150. (The actual tally was 92 in 2014.) The poll, while indicating that the Modi-led NDA was heading for a majority, gave it only 212 seats. It was unable to predict the decisive win that saw the BJP getting 282 seats on its own and the NDA total being 336. One reason was that the vote for change gathered momentum in the last mile, sending the BJP and NDA numbers soaring.

The MOTN figures for the NDA this time do fall short of the landslide win of 400-plus that Modi hopes the BJP and its NDA allies will win. With barely two months to go for the election, Yashwant Deshmukh, founder-director, CVoter, says, "The figure of 400-plus seems improbable right now, but not impossible." And that is because, he adds, the current INDIA TODAY-CVoter projections are conservative and the final two months of the poll could see both Modi and the NDA gather further steam, which could help them achieve their ambitious target.

The 304 seats the current MOTN gives are conservative. Modi and the BJP could see a last-mile surge to meet their 400-seat target

THE QUEST FOR 400

So, which are the states where the BJP is likely to boost the MOTN prediction of 304 seats and add another 66 seats to take its tally to 370? The BJP, as in 2014 and 2019, is likely to contest only 436 seats, leaving the remaining 100-odd seats to the NDA partners. The BJP's strike rate in the past two general elections averaged a majestic 67 per cent. In 2024, they will have to push that to an incredible 84 per cent. In short, the party will require a massive wave in its favour to achieve its 370-seat target.

It is a tough ask but not an impossible one. In 2019, the BJP won 224 of its 303 seats by a margin of over 50 per cent, which makes the party well nigh invincible in these seats. In 72 seats, the BJP lost by a margin of less than the national average of 200,000. These are the seats the BJP is now focusing its